

Aquifer Open Study Notes

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Aquifer Open Study Notes

1 Peter 1:1

to God's chosen people: Peter opens his letter to suffering Christians by reminding them of the status they enjoy because of God's act on their behalf ([1:2](#)). • living as foreigners (literally *exiles of the dispersion*): An exile had been uprooted from his or her homeland and taken to live in a foreign country. Peter uses the concept metaphorically to remind Christians that they are living in a world dominated by anti-Christian values and ways of life. • Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia were Roman provinces in what is now Turkey. They might be listed in the order of the route that a messenger would have followed while carrying the letter to the various churches.

1 Peter 1:2

knew you and chose you: When God knows a person, it means that he chooses that person. He chose to enter into relationship with his people before they knew him (cp. [Rom 8:29](#); [11:2](#)).

1 Peter 1:3

born again: New birth is a way of describing Christian conversion (cp. [John 3:1-13](#); [Jas 1:18](#); [1 Jn 2:29](#); [3:9](#); [4:7](#); [5:1](#), [4](#), [18](#)). This Greek word, which occurs again in [1 Pet 1:23](#), brackets the message of [1:1-25](#).

1 Peter 1:3-9

In most New Testament letters, the greeting is followed by a section of thanksgiving or praise. Peter praises God that his mercy brings new spiritual life, which produces confident expectation about the future despite sufferings in the meantime.

1 Peter 1:4

The language of inheritance frequently refers to what God has promised his people. Originally

applied to the land of Israel (see [Deut 3:28](#)), the *inheritance* came to mean the people of God and God's presence with them (see [Ps 33:12](#); [Ezek 44:28](#)). In the New Testament, the inheritance is the spiritual benefit and eternal salvation that God promises to his people (see [Eph 1:11](#); [Heb 9:15](#)).

1 Peter 1:5

until you receive this salvation: In the New Testament, *salvation* often refers to final rescue from sin and death at the time of Christ's return. This hope encourages believers to persevere to the end (see also [1:9](#), [10](#); [2:2](#); [4:18](#)). • ready to be revealed: The future revealing of God's salvation contrasts with the present hiddenness of God and his purposes (see also [1:7](#), [13](#)).

1 Peter 1:7

will show that your faith is genuine: Faith, like gold, is purified as it is tested. • The NLT understands praise and glory and honor as being given by God to the faithful Christian. The phrase could also mean that a faithful Christian life brings *praise and glory and honor* to God.

1 Peter 1:9

salvation of your souls: The Greek word translated *souls* often refers to the whole person and not just to some part or aspect of the person ([Matt 20:28](#); [Mark 8:35](#)). Salvation affects our whole person, not the inner person only.

1 Peter 1:10-12

Our salvation is very great: The Old Testament prophets predicted it, and angels long to investigate it.

1 Peter 1:11

They wondered: Much was revealed about the future to the Old Testament prophets, but they did

not know precisely when or how the salvation they predicted would come about. • The Greek translated what time could also mean *what person*. The prophets knew that a Messiah would come and that he would suffer before he was glorified, but they did not know who that Messiah would be.

1 Peter 1:12

eagerly watching: The same Greek word is used of the disciples when they peered into Jesus' empty tomb ([Luke 24:12](#); [John 20:5, 11](#)).

1 Peter 1:13

prepare your minds for action (literally *gird the loins of your mind*): In Peter's day, a man had to tuck the hem of his long robe into his belt before he could work or run.

1 Peter 1:13–21

New birth and the hope of salvation require that Christians live as God's people, separating themselves from the values of the world and emulating the holiness of God, who redeemed them.

1 Peter 1:15–16

"You must be holy because I am holy": This is a common refrain in Scripture, that God's people must be holy as God is holy (see [Lev 11:44–45](#); [19:2](#); [20:7](#); see also [Ezek 20:12](#); [Eph 1:4](#); [1 Thes 4:3](#); [Rev 22:11](#)).

1 Peter 1:17

Christians' citizenship is in heaven ([1:1](#); see [Phil 3:20](#)); they live in this world as "temporary residents" who are uncomfortable with its values and who long for their true home.

1 Peter 1:18

A ransom is paid for the release of a captive. Slaves could sometimes pay a ransom and be released

from their master. Christ's death is the price God paid to release people from captivity to sin ([1:19](#)).

1 Peter 1:19

the sinless, spotless Lamb of God: The Passover *Lamb* had to be without defect ([Exod 12:5](#)); Christ, who fulfills the meaning of the Passover, was without defect or sin (cp. [Heb 4:14–16](#); [7:26–28](#)).

1 Peter 1:20

With Christ's coming, Old Testament promises of redemption are being fulfilled and the last days have begun.

1 Peter 1:22

must show sincere love to each other as brothers and sisters: Literally *must have brotherly love*. See study note on 5:9.

1 Peter 1:22–2.3

Following his call for holiness ([1:13–21](#)), Peter specifies how believers must live in a loving way with fellow Christians.

1 Peter 2:2

Believers, who have been "born again" ([1:23](#)), are to be like newborn babies in naturally and regularly craving pure spiritual milk. Elsewhere in the New Testament, *milk* (in contrast to solid food) stands for elementary Christian teaching ([1 Cor 3:2](#); [Heb 5:12–13](#)). This does not imply that Peter's readers are new believers, however; here, it probably refers to God's word in general.

1 Peter 2:3

now that you have had a taste of the Lord's kindness: The words are taken from [Ps 34:8](#). Peter quotes this psalm again in [1 Pet 3:10–12](#).

1 Peter 2:4

rejected by people, but he was chosen by God for great honor: This is an allusion to [Ps 118:22](#), which is quoted in [1 Pet 2:7](#).

1 Peter 2:4–10

Throughout the letter, Peter encourages the suffering believers by reminding them of their exalted spiritual status. In this paragraph, he presents the Christian community as the new temple built on the foundation of Christ, and as heirs of the blessings granted to God's covenant people.

1 Peter 2:5

God's people themselves constitute the spiritual temple where God dwells ([1 Cor 3:16](#)). Jesus compared his body to a "temple" ([John 2:19–22](#)), and the church is called the "body of Christ" ([Eph 4:12](#)). God no longer manifests himself in a particular place but in the people who belong to him and praise his goodness (see [1 Pet 2:10](#)). • As God's holy priests in the new covenant, Christians offer not animal sacrifices but spiritual sacrifices such as praising God, praying, and doing good (see [Rom 12:1](#); [Heb 13:15–16](#)).

1 Peter 2:6–8

The three Old Testament quotations in these verses each identify Christ as some kind of stone: the cornerstone on which the new temple is built ([2:6](#)); the cornerstone that God, despite peoples' rejection, has elevated to be the keystone of his redemptive plan ([2:7](#)); and the stone that makes people stumble ([2:8](#)). Jesus quotes [Ps 118:22](#) ([Matt 21:42](#)), and Paul quotes both [Isa 8:14](#) and [28:16](#) ([Rom 9:33](#)). Likely these three quotations were brought together very early as a combined Old Testament testimony to the nature and significance of Jesus the Messiah.

1 Peter 2:8

they meet the fate that was planned for them (literally *for which they were appointed*): It is not clear whether these people were appointed by God

to unbelief or whether they were, because of their unbelief, appointed by God to suffer condemnation.

1 Peter 2:9

Peter applies descriptions of the Israelites in the Old Testament (see, e.g., [Exod 19:5–6](#)) to his primarily Gentile audience, indicating that they—like all Christians—are truly God's people in the new covenant era.

1 Peter 2:11

"temporary residents and foreigners": Believers belong not to this world but to the Kingdom of Heaven (see [1:1](#), 17).

1 Peter 2:11–12

These verses are transitional. They can be viewed as the finale to the first section of the letter or as the opening statement of the second section of the letter. They enunciate the letter's central theme: Christians living in hostile territory need to live out the principles of the Good News so that they can win other people to the Lord.

1 Peter 2:12

when he judges the world (or *on the day of visitation*): The phrase *day of visitation* is used in the Greek Old Testament to describe the time when God will visit his enemies to judge them ([Isa 10:3](#); [Jer 6:15](#)).

1 Peter 2:13

In Peter's day, the king was the Roman emperor. Christians were suffering in the hands of the state and would soon suffer more intensely under Nero.

1 Peter 2:13–3.7

This section revolves around the key phrase submit to all human authority, which Peter applies to several relationships: Christians should accept the authority of those in government ([2:13–17](#)),

Christian slaves should accept the authority of their masters (2:18-25), and Christian wives should accept the authority of their husbands (3:1-6). Peter seems to be following an early Christian usage of the traditional household code, in which a series of instructions was given for different members of the household (cp. Eph 5:21-6:9; Col 3:18-4:1; 1 Tim 5:1-6:2; Titus 2:1-10).

1 Peter 2:14

to punish those who do wrong and honor those who do right: Cp. Rom 13:3-4.

1 Peter 2:17

the family of believers: Literally *the brotherhood*; see study note on 5:9. • Fear God, and respect the king: Peter might be reflecting on Jesus' balanced statement about the Christian's duty to both God and the government (see Matt 22:21).

1 Peter 2:18

Many slaves in the Roman Empire held responsible positions and had a decent income, but most were harshly treated and all were deprived of legal status and rights. • with all respect (literally *with all fear*): Peter might be calling on slaves to fear God (see 2:17; cp. 1:17) or the master's punishment, but he often speaks this way about the respectful attitude Christians must have toward others (3:16).

1 Peter 2:18-20

The slave was legally bound and could not change his or her master, whereas the modern employee has the right to stop working for a cruel employer. Of course, some employees may not be able to change their situation, in which case Peter's advice to slaves is very applicable to employees today.

1 Peter 2:21-25

While there is no explicit change of address here, the general character of these verses makes them applicable to all believers. • These verses might incorporate an early Christian hymn or confession

about Christ (2:22-25). Its focus is on the redemptive sufferings of Christ in language drawn largely from Isaiah 52:13-53:12.

1 Peter 2:24

He personally carried our sins: This phrase alludes to Isa 53:4, 11-12. • By his wounds you are healed: The physical suffering of Christ has freed us from slavery to sin (cp. Isa 53:5). Matthew applies similar language from Isa 53:4 to the physical healings performed by Jesus (Matt 8:17).

1 Peter 3:1

accept the authority of (literally *submit to*): Wives are instructed to acknowledge that God has appointed the husband as head of the relationship (see 2:13; Eph 5:22-25). Submission in the ancient world took the form of obedience (see 1 Pet 3:6). God also intends the husband to be a loving and respectful head (3:7; see Eph 5:25-30). However, Peter focuses especially on wives with pagan husbands who would potentially be hostile toward their wives' faith. • without any words: Peter urges Christian wives to evangelize their husbands through their submissive and appropriate behavior.

1 Peter 3:1-7

The last of Peter's three exhortations about accepting authority (2:13-3:7) concerns wives and husbands (cp. Eph 5:21-33; Col 3:18-19).

1 Peter 3:3-4

fancy hairstyles, expensive jewelry, or beautiful clothes: Peter has sometimes been interpreted as if he condemns any form of female ornamentation, but this is not his purpose. Instead, he insists that Christian women should not be noticed for the beauty of clothing and jewels but for the interior beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit. See also 1 Tim 2:9-10.

1 Peter 3:6

and called him her master: See [Gen 18:12](#). Peter views this address as indicative of Sarah's overall attitude toward Abraham. • without fear of what your husbands might do: Christian wives married to unbelievers frequently found themselves pressured, both subtly and overtly, to abandon Christian principles and values. Peter urges them to continue to do what is right.

1 Peter 3:7

In the same way: Like slaves and wives ([2:18–3:6](#)), husbands also have a particular responsibility within the household. • She may be weaker than you are: Peter was probably thinking of the woman's physical strength and perhaps her social status. Since women are typically physically weaker than men and were often less able to assert themselves in that society, the husband had the duty of protecting and caring for his wife. • your equal partner in God's gift of new life: The husband's headship is balanced and informed by the equal status that men and women have before God (see also [Gal 3:26–29](#)). • The prayers of a husband are hindered if he does not give exceptional honor to his wife (cp. [Jas 4:3](#)).

1 Peter 3:8–12

Finally: This is the last in a series of exhortations to different groups ([2:13–3:12](#)). Here, all believers must respond to others—believers ([3:8](#)) and unbelievers ([3:9–12](#))—with love.

1 Peter 3:9

and he grant you his blessing: By blessing others, we receive a blessing from God.

1 Peter 3:10–12

Peter underscores the relationship between conduct and blessing by quoting [Ps 34:12–16](#). This psalm is prominent in early Christian teaching (see also [1 Pet 2:3](#); [Heb 12:14](#)). The text focuses on curbing sins of speech, resisting evil, and doing good. It also highlights the promise of blessing for obedience.

1 Peter 3:13

Generally speaking, no one will want to harm someone who is doing good, but sometimes Christians do suffer even when they do good ([3:14](#); see [1:6](#); [4:12–19](#)).

1 Peter 3:13–17

This short paragraph emphasizes the Christian response to suffering—following Christ's example ([3:18](#)).

1 Peter 3:14–15

or be afraid of their threats: See [Isa 8:13](#), where God exhorts the prophet to fear nothing except the Lord. • worship Christ as Lord: By fearing Christ, they will be free from fear of their human persecutors.

1 Peter 3:18

He suffered physical death (literally *death in the flesh*), but he was raised to life in the Spirit (or *in spirit*): *Flesh* and *spirit* are often contrasted (e.g., [Rom 7:5–6](#); [8:2–11](#)). Here, *flesh* stands for ordinary human life; the Spirit stands for the new realm inaugurated through Christ's death and resurrection. Christ died in the old realm and came to life in the new realm.

1 Peter 3:18–22

As in [2:21–25](#), Peter again appeals to Christ, who was righteous and yet suffered, as an example for believers facing persecution ([3:13–17](#)). The unique work of Christ on our behalf reminds suffering Christians that they have a secure foundation for hope and confidence.

1 Peter 3:19–20

This difficult passage has been widely interpreted in three ways: (1) One interpretation holds that it refers to the spirits of people who have died and that Christ, after his resurrection, preached the

Good News to these *spirits*. However, the idea that people might hear the Good News and respond after their deaths is not found elsewhere in the New Testament, and this meaning of *spirits* is not the most likely. (2) A second interpretation sees [3:19-20](#) as describing Christ's preaching through Noah to people who are now spirits in prison. This interpretation does justice to [3:20](#) but does not fit well in the discussion of Christ's death and resurrection ([3:18](#)). (3) In the third interpretation, *the spirits in prison* are evil spiritual beings. Jewish tradition, based on [Gen 6:1-4](#), held that many angels fell in the time of Noah (see also [Jude 1:6](#); [1 Enoch 6-10](#)). Peter's point would then be that Christ proclaimed his victory over the evil spiritual powers after his resurrection (cp. [1 Pet 3:22](#)).

1 Peter 3:20

Only eight people: That is, Noah, his wife, their three sons, and their wives ([Gen 6:18](#); [8:18](#)).

1 Peter 3:21

a picture of baptism: Peter might mean that, as the water floated the boat in which Noah and his family were saved, so *baptism* saves believers. Or he might mean that, as Noah and his family passed through *water* to safety, so Christians pass through the waters of *baptism* to salvation. Finally, he might mean that, as the *water* judged sin in Noah's day, so the water of *baptism* washes away the sins of Christians. • Peter does not mean that water baptism saves a person regardless of that person's heart. He adds that baptism saves only as a response to God from (or *as an appeal to God for*) a clean conscience, thus making clear that only people exercising faith toward God will benefit from baptism.

1 Peter 3:22

all the angels and authorities and powers accept his authority: In the ancient world, spiritual beings were widely believed to directly affect the course of affairs on earth. Christians needed to be reminded that Christ has already won his victory over these spiritual powers. It means that we don't need to fear even the spiritual realm (cp. [3:14](#)).

1 Peter 4:1

since Christ suffered physical pain: Peter introduced this idea in [3:18](#); he now indicates its significance in Christian experience. In our own physical sufferings, we are to imitate Christ's attitude (see [2:21-24](#)). Our suffering with Christ shows that we have identified with him (see [Rom 8:17](#)). Those who identify with Christ experience the victory over the power of sin that he won on the cross ([Rom 6:1-10](#)).

1 Peter 4:1-6

Peter urges Christians to decisively turn their backs on the former sinful way of life from which Christ in his suffering delivered us.

1 Peter 4:3

godless people (literally *the Gentiles*): Peter takes this term from his Jewish heritage to describe those who do not know God.

1 Peter 4:6

Peter refers to people now dead who were exposed to the Good News while alive; he does not envision a chance to repent after death. If they responded in faith to the message in life, they can be confident that, although they were destined to die like all people, they will live forever with God in the Spirit.

1 Peter 4:7

The end of the world is coming soon: At Christ's coming, the "last days" predicted by the Old Testament prophets had begun (see [1:10-12](#)). The next event in salvation history is the second coming of Christ, which will bring the *end* of the world as we know it. The *end* could come at any time; therefore, Christians must always be ready for it (see also [Phil 4:5](#); [Jas 5:8](#); [Rev 1:3](#); [22:10](#)).

1 Peter 4:7-11

With this paragraph of miscellaneous exhortations, Peter concludes the third major section of the letter ([3:13-4:11](#)).

1 Peter 4:8

By its nature, love overlooks sins committed against us by others (see [Prov 10:12](#); [Matt 18:21–22](#); [1 Cor 13:4–7](#)). Peter might also mean that our attitude of love, because it displays our relationship with Christ, covers our own sins and causes them to be forgiven (see [Luke 7:47](#)).

1 Peter 4:10

- *manifold grace of God*: This refers to the variety of spiritual gifts God has given to followers of Jesus. See [Romans 12:6–8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:1–31](#); [Ephesians 4:7–16](#).
- *use (literally manage) whatever gift*: Christians are like managers. They have been trusted by God, their Master, with gifts to be used to bring glory to him.

1 Peter 4:11

All glory and power to him forever and ever! Amen: This doxology has led some to suggest that one original letter of Peter ended here and that another one was added to it. Doxologies in the New Testament do appear at the end of letters ([Rom 16:25–27](#); [Phil 4:20](#); [Heb 13:21](#); [2 Pet 3:18](#); [Jude 1:24–25](#)), but also at the end of sections within letters ([Rom 11:36](#); [Gal 1:5](#); [Eph 3:21](#); [1 Tim 1:17](#)). Since there is no textual evidence for the existence of two separate letters, it is better to assume that this doxology marks the end of a major section of the letter.

1 Peter 4:12

don't be surprised: Christians, especially those seeking to lead godly lives, can expect to face the hostility of a sinful world (see [John 16:33](#); [Acts 14:22](#); [Rom 8:17](#); [Phil 1:29](#)).

1 Peter 4:12–19

Peter instructs Christians one last time about the way to face the trials that will inevitably come.

1 Peter 4:13

Christians are called to suffer with Christ in order to be glorified with him (see also [Rom 8:17](#)).

1 Peter 4:14

If you are insulted because you bear the name of Christ, you will be blessed (literally *you are blessed when you are reproached*): This verse reflects Jesus' teaching in [Matt 5:11–12](#).

1 Peter 4:16

Although evidence is very fragmentary, it is likely that the label Christian (cp. [Acts 11:26](#)) was originally a convenient way of summarizing the alleged superstitious practices and immoral character attributed to Jesus' followers.

1 Peter 4:17

God's judgment is often pictured as beginning with God's household—i.e., with his own people—as a means of purifying them ([Jer 25:29](#); [Ezek 9:5–6](#); [Mal 3:1–6](#)).

1 Peter 5:1–4

Elders were the spiritual leaders of the early churches (see also [Acts 14:23](#); [20:17](#); [1 Tim 5:17–19](#); [Titus 1:5](#); [Jas 5:14](#)). By calling himself a fellow elder, Peter identifies with them in their responsibilities and with the charge that he gives them.

1 Peter 5:1–14

Peter ends the letter with final exhortations to elders ([5:1–4](#)), to younger people ([5:5](#)), and to the church as a whole ([5:5–11](#)). These exhortations are followed by final greetings and a closing ([5:12–14](#)).

1 Peter 5:2

Care for the flock (literally *Shepherd the flock*): Our word *pastor* comes from New Testament imagery of a shepherd pasturing his flock.

1 Peter 5:5

You who are younger: This phrase, in contrast to the elders, might refer to a particular class of ministers, perhaps elders in training or those who assisted the elders in various ways. But probably it simply denotes the younger individuals in the church (see, e.g., [1 Jn 2:12-14](#)).

1 Peter 5:9

family of believers: Greek adelphoi, a term that refers to people, both male and female, who are members of the same family. • all over the world: Persecution was not confined to the churches of Asia Minor. In various forms and with varying intensity, Christians were persecuted almost everywhere the Good News about Jesus Christ was preached. Peter reminds his readers of this to console them and encourage them to emulate those who had successfully endured the test of suffering.

1 Peter 5:10

a little while: Sufferings on this earth—while sometimes appearing to be endless—are in fact only momentary compared with the glorious eternity that believers will spend with God (cp. [1:6](#); [Rom 8:18](#); [2 Cor 4:16-18](#)).

1 Peter 5:12

with the help of: This phrase identifies Silas as the *amanuensis*, the person who wrote the words as Peter directed. • Silas (Greek *Silvanus*): Silas is the shortened form of Silvanus; both names refer to the same individual. Silas was Paul's constant colleague after the time of the council in Jerusalem ([Acts 15:40](#); [16:19](#); [17:10](#), [14-15](#); [18:5](#); [2 Cor 1:19](#); [1 Thes 1:1](#); [2 Thes 1:1](#)). We are not sure how Silas ended up with Peter in Rome, but he may have traveled with or followed Paul ([Acts 27:1-28:31](#)).

1 Peter 5:13

Babylon was probably symbolic for Rome. Like Rome, Babylon was a great city, the capital of an empire. Babylon held sway over much of the ancient Near East in the 500s BC. As a great city and the capital of the empire that burned Jerusalem and took many captive Israelites back to the city, Babylon was regarded as the power center of a world hostile to God's people. For this reason, the book of Revelation uses "Babylon" as a metaphor or code word for Rome. Peter probably also used the title in the same way. • Mark, also called John Mark, was another co-worker of the apostle Paul. Mark wrote the Gospel of Mark, which is generally thought to be based on Peter's teachings.

1 Peter 5:14

a kiss of love: See study note on Rom 16:16.